

## ADAPTCLOUD

### PARTNER-LED VENDOR CREDIBILITY AND OBJECTION HANDLING

# The partner operating loop

| VERSION              | DATE OF ISSUE     | CLASSIFICATION | APPLIES TO                 |
|----------------------|-------------------|----------------|----------------------------|
| 1.0                  | September 6, 2026 | Internal       | Every partner conversation |
| OWNER                |                   |                |                            |
| AdaptCloud principal |                   |                |                            |

## 1 Objective and core rule

**Objective.** Position AdaptCloud as a credible, low-risk, margin-positive platform partner without overstating company age, customer history, certifications, or delivery scale.

**Core rule.** Do not attempt to sound established.

Demonstrate established-vendor behavior through repeatable commercial, delivery, support, evidence, and governance mechanisms. An experienced vendor reduces uncertainty. Every mechanism in this document exists to reduce a specific uncertainty a partner is carrying.

### 1.1 Language that is never used

**Never** "We are just like [large vendor], but cheaper."

**Never** "Our AI handles compliance."

**Never** "We have broad enterprise experience," unless tied to named people and verifiable work.

**Never** "We guarantee certification or compliance."

**Never** "We are still figuring out our channel model."

## 2 Partner type and non-overlapping responsibilities

Identify the partner type first. Responsibilities must not overlap, and the boundary is stated before the product is shown.

EXHIBIT 1 – RESPONSIBILITY SPLIT BY PARTNER TYPE

| PARTNER TYPE    | PARTNER OWNS                                                                                            | ADAPTCLOUD OWNS                                      | BOUNDARY                                                      |
|-----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Distribution    | Transacts: catalog, vehicle access, purchase orders, renewals                                           | Product, fulfillment, all delivery                   | No delivery obligation. Does not access client environments.  |
| Delivery        | Client relationship; supplies and manages consultants; delivers under its own brand after accreditation | Product, enablement, escalation, second-line support | Accreditation required before independent production delivery |
| Strategic / GSI | Account relationship and delivery model                                                                 | Platform, enablement, quality framework, escalation  | We do not pursue the partner's registered accounts directly.  |

## 3 Commercial posture and operating model

State the posture, then present the operating model, **before** the product demonstration. A partner who has not yet been told who owns the client cannot evaluate a demo.

"AdaptCloud is a focused compliance-automation platform designed for partner-led delivery. We do not ask partners to assume open-ended product, delivery, or commercial risk. We provide a defined delivery method, accreditation, controlled escalation, account protection, and transparent economics."

### 3.1 The operating model, stated in order

- 1The partner owns the client relationship.
- 2The partner chooses services attach per opportunity.
- 3AdaptCloud owns the platform.
- 4AdaptCloud provides enablement and second-line support.
- 5AdaptCloud does not sell directly into accepted, registered partner opportunities.
- 6Early engagements are bounded, paid, joint proof engagements.

## 4 Qualification gate

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Seven checks. All must be answerable before a proposal is made.

- |           |                                                                                      |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Q1</b> | Is there a defined client problem?                                                   |
| <b>Q2</b> | Is the client environment suitable?                                                  |
| <b>Q3</b> | Are prerequisites known?                                                             |
| <b>Q4</b> | Is there a named partner delivery lead?                                              |
| <b>Q5</b> | Is the opportunity large enough to support proper delivery?                          |
| <b>Q6</b> | Is the customer willing to agree to measurable success criteria?                     |
| <b>Q7</b> | Can the engagement produce reusable evidence, a case study, or a reference artifact? |

**If qualification is incomplete:** do not quote universal timelines, do not promise broad product compatibility, and do not commit unbounded support. Schedule discovery and produce a written scope with assumptions, dependencies, exclusions, and acceptance criteria.

## 5 Objection loop

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For every objection raised: identify the underlying concern, respond with a bounded commercial or operating mechanism, show a relevant proof artifact, document the objection and agreed mitigation, and confirm the partner accepts the mitigation before advancing.

The customer-facing wording of these answers is published on the website FAQ. What follows is the internal version, carrying the action each answer commits us to.

**"You are new. Why should we risk our client relationship?"**

**SAY**

Do not place an unbounded bet on us. Start with a partner-led, paid proof engagement with fixed scope, explicit acceptance criteria, agreed escalation procedures, and documented outcomes.

**SHOW**

Fixed-scope pilot package · statement of work · acceptance criteria · escalation matrix · post-engagement outcome report

**ACTION**

Offer a paid proof engagement. **Do not offer an undefined free pilot.** Capture baseline and outcome metrics.

### "What happens if the platform fails in the client environment?"

#### SAY

The partner remains client-facing. AdaptCloud provides defined second-line product support, severity-based escalation, documented rollback procedures, and support boundaries appropriate to the contracted scope.

#### SHOW

Support policy · severity definitions · escalation path · release notes · rollback and recovery procedure

#### ACTION

Define ownership in the RACI. Confirm the support tier before contract signature. **Avoid commitments not backed by the support model.**

### "Will you go direct after we create demand?"

#### SAY

No. Accepted deal registration protects the partner-sourced account for the registered use case. AdaptCloud will not quote, sell, contract with, or solicit that account outside the originating partner without written partner approval.

#### SHOW

Deal-registration policy · account-protection period · non-circumvention language · conflict-resolution process

#### ACTION

Register the deal **before** substantive joint activity. Log account, use case, partner, date, and protection period. Establish inactivity rules and renewal treatment in writing.

### "Can our consultants deliver this without you?"

#### SAY

Yes, after accreditation. We co-deliver the earliest engagements to transfer the method. Accredited partner consultants lead subsequent deliveries, while AdaptCloud remains available for product escalation and quality support.

#### SHOW

Accreditation curriculum · lab environment · delivery runbook · QA checklist · re-certification requirements

#### ACTION

Require accreditation before independent production delivery. Co-deliver the first two to three suitable engagements. Audit delivery quality before granting expanded partner privileges.

### "What margin do we make?"

#### SAY

The economics are visible before you allocate sales or delivery resources. Partners receive software resale margin, retain the majority of partner-delivered services revenue, and have defined incentives for renewals and qualified expansion.

**SHOW**

Partner rate card · margin schedule · sample deal economics · discount policy · renewal model

**ACTION**

Present margin bands early. Use exact terms only in the partner agreement. Tie higher discounts to accreditation, annual commitment, volume, or qualified pipeline. **Protect a pricing floor for registered opportunities.**

**"Why not use an established platform?"**

**SAY**

Use the incumbent where it is already the operational standard. Use AdaptCloud where the problem is repeatable evidence creation, faster control implementation, a partner-owned delivery motion, or a defined compliance-automation use case. We compete on a focused wedge, not a claim to replace every enterprise platform.

**SHOW**

Narrow use-case comparison · demonstrable workflow · evidence-output example · time-to-value estimate for the qualified scope

**ACTION**

Do not make broad replacement claims. Focus on one specific high-value workflow. **Demonstrate the actual product, not roadmap concepts.**

**"Can you substantiate the compliance outputs?"**

**SAY**

Every output must be traceable to its source, version, execution context, reviewer, and supporting artifact. Platform-generated analysis is distinct from client-attested evidence and from an assessor's determination.

**SHOW**

Evidence model · source and version traceability · audit trail · sample evidence export · human-review workflow

**ACTION**

**Never claim the platform independently certifies a client.** Identify automated versus human-reviewed outputs. Preserve provenance for each material artifact. Version all control mappings and evidence references.

**"Your team is too small to support us."**

**SAY**

We control capacity rather than overcommit. The model transfers repeatable delivery work to accredited partner teams while AdaptCloud focuses on platform evolution and second-line escalation.

**SHOW**

Capacity plan · partner-tier model · onboarding gates · support boundaries

**ACTION**

Cap launch partner cohorts. Limit concurrent co-deliveries. Do not promise global support coverage unless operationally available. Escalate capacity conflicts **before** accepting work.

**"What if your company does not survive?"**

**SAY**

We address continuity directly through exportable evidence, documented configurations, transition assistance, and an appropriate continuity plan. The customer's work product must remain usable without dependence on a single vendor relationship.

**SHOW**

Data-export process · transition-assistance terms · documentation standard · continuity plan

**ACTION**

Keep customer evidence exportable. Document configurations and integrations. Offer escrow only where commercially and operationally appropriate. **Do not promise arrangements that are not contractually supported.**

**"AI creates unacceptable risk."**

**SAY**

AI may assist workflow and analysis, but it does not replace accountable human judgment, client attestation, or assessor authority. Material outputs are reviewable, traceable, and governed by defined policies.

**SHOW**

AI usage policy · human-review controls · logging model · output-validation procedure

**ACTION**

Keep humans accountable for material conclusions. Document AI-assisted versus deterministic outputs. **Do not market AI as autonomous compliance certification.**

**"What are we actually selling?"**

**SAY**

The offer is separable: platform subscription, partner-delivered professional services, and optional AdaptCloud enablement or specialist support. Each component has distinct pricing, scope, and accountability.

**SHOW**

Offer catalog · software order form · services statement of work · RACI · support tiers

**ACTION**

Keep software, services, and enablement commercially distinct. **Avoid burying implementation obligations inside subscription language.** Confirm who contracts with the customer for each component.

**"Will you undercut us?"**

**SAY**

Registered opportunities receive protected pricing. AdaptCloud will not quote below the agreed partner price floor into a protected account, and exceptions require joint approval.

**SHOW**

Discount-approval policy · opportunity-registration rules · price-floor protection

**ACTION**

Record the approved commercial structure. Route all pricing exceptions through named channel leadership. **Do not give direct client quotes on partner-registered accounts.**

**"Who are your customer references?"**

**SAY**

We will not invent references. Early reference engagements are deliberately structured as joint, partner-led proof engagements with measurable outcomes, NDA case-study rights, and the option to create a named reference if the client approves.

**SHOW**

Reference-rights ladder · anonymized case-study template · outcome scorecard · client-approval workflow

**ACTION**

Secure permission in writing. Begin with internal evidence. Move from anonymized to named case study only with client consent. **Never imply an endorsement that was not granted.**

**"How long will implementation take?"**

#### SAY

We provide a phased plan after qualification. The timeline depends on environment readiness, control scope, integrations, client participation, and partner staffing. We define milestones, responsibilities, prerequisites, and a clear definition of done.

#### SHOW

Discovery checklist · delivery plan · dependency register · milestone schedule

#### ACTION

**Do not give an unconditional timeline before discovery.** Make client and partner dependencies explicit. Use fixed-scope proof packages for predictable early delivery.

## 6 Commercial guardrails

For every proposed deal, separate revenue into software subscription, partner-delivered services, AdaptCloud co-delivery or specialist support, accreditation and enablement, and renewals and expansion. Then apply the bands.

### EXHIBIT 2 — INDICATIVE MARGIN BANDS

| COMPONENT                        | BAND            | CONDITION                                       |
|----------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Distribution resale              | 10–20%          | Transacts only; no delivery obligation          |
| Delivery-partner software resale | 20–35%          | When sourcing and owning the opportunity        |
| Partner-delivered services       | 60–80% retained | Partner owns delivery                           |
| AdaptCloud co-delivery           | 20–40%          | Of services value, or a defined specialist rate |
| Qualified renewal influence      | 5–20%           | Depending on partner role and agreement         |

### 6.1 Margin protection stop condition

**If a deal combines maximum software discount, maximum services margin, unlimited support, and extensive custom development — stop.**

Re-price the deal. Separate custom work from the standard offer. Add a support tier or specialist-services charge. Require leadership approval. A deal that produces partner enthusiasm while destroying the ability to support the program is not a win.

### 6.2 Deal quality requirements

**D1** Paid proof engagement, not undefined free work

**D2** Fixed scope



|           |                                |
|-----------|--------------------------------|
| <b>D3</b> | Measurable success criteria    |
| <b>D4</b> | Partner ownership documented   |
| <b>D5</b> | Capacity confirmed             |
| <b>D6</b> | Support tier selected          |
| <b>D7</b> | Account registered             |
| <b>D8</b> | Client prerequisites validated |

### 6.3 Approval test

Approve only if the partner has meaningful economic upside, AdaptCloud retains sufficient margin for product, support and escalation, the client receives a clear value proposition, delivery risk is bounded, and the engagement can create reusable proof.

## 7 Proof-engagement loop

Completion is not proof. A measured before-and-after result, traceable output, and client acceptance are proof.

|           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>P1</b> | <b>Establish the baseline.</b> Controls incomplete or unverified, evidence artifacts missing or fragmented, remediation backlog, time and cost of the current manual process, delivery effort required.                                                       |
| <b>P2</b> | <b>Define the target outcome.</b> Evidence created or normalized, controls assessed, remediation rules produced, review cycle shortened, rework reduced, partner delivery method validated.                                                                   |
| <b>P3</b> | <b>Define acceptance.</b> Required artifacts, reviewers, evidence standard, timeline, delivery responsibilities, client responsibilities, explicit exclusions.                                                                                                |
| <b>P4</b> | <b>Deliver.</b> Partner leads the client relationship, accredited partner personnel perform delivery, AdaptCloud provides enablement and escalation, evidence provenance is preserved, issues and decisions and changes are tracked.                          |
| <b>P5</b> | <b>Close.</b> Obtain client acceptance, produce a before-and-after scorecard, capture partner QA findings, document reusable control checks and remediation rules and reference modules, request permission for internal, anonymized, or named reference use. |

### 7.1 Library contribution

$$\text{reusable\_library\_ratio} = \text{reusable\_validated\_artifacts} \div \text{total\_material\_artifacts\_created}$$

Use the result to improve the delivery runbook, the accreditation content, the evidence library, and future scoping. Validated metrics may be used in subsequent partner discussions. **Do not publish claims beyond the measured and permissioned evidence.**

## 8 Required assets, and current status

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Before scaling partner recruitment, each asset must exist and be current. Status is assessed as of the date of issue.

### EXHIBIT 3 — ASSET REGISTER

| ASSET                                             | STATUS   | NOTE                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------------------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Capability statement                              | IN PLACE | Page one of both partner briefs                                                                                |
| Partner rate card and economics sheet             | PARTIAL  | Margin framework published in both briefs; no standalone rate card or sample deal economics                    |
| Objection handling                                | IN PLACE | Website FAQ, plus section 5 of this document                                                                   |
| Product roadmap and current-capability disclosure | PARTIAL  | Coverage exhibit and capability statement exist; no published roadmap                                          |
| Fixed-scope proof-engagement package              | PARTIAL  | Pilot structure and exit criterion defined in the co-delivery brief; not a packaged SOW                        |
| Partner program guide                             | MISSING  | Tiers, eligibility, benefits, responsibilities, certification, support limits, rules of engagement, escalation |
| Rules-of-engagement addendum                      | IN PLACE | Registration, protection, lapse, renewal, pricing governance, conflict resolution, and a parameters table      |
| Deal-registration form and tracker                | IN PLACE | Fourteen-field form, decision criteria, tracker record, and a closed status vocabulary                         |
| Partner accreditation curriculum                  | MISSING  | Gates independent production delivery                                                                          |
| Delivery runbook                                  | MISSING  |                                                                                                                |
| Quality-assurance checklist                       | MISSING  |                                                                                                                |
| Evidence and provenance statement                 | MISSING  | Supports the substantiation answer in section 5                                                                |
| AI-use and human-review policy                    | MISSING  | Supports the AI-risk answer in section 5                                                                       |
| Support policy and severity matrix                | MISSING  | Supports the failure-in-environment answer in section 5                                                        |
| Security and continuity packet                    | MISSING  |                                                                                                                |
| Data-export and transition process                | MISSING  | Supports the continuity answer in section 5                                                                    |
| Reference-rights template                         | MISSING  |                                                                                                                |
| Case-study template                               | MISSING  |                                                                                                                |

Most rows marked missing above are the proof artifacts cited by an objection answer in section 5. Those answers may still be given, because each describes a commitment we are prepared to make, but the artifact must exist before the commitment is contracted. The account-protection answer is now fully covered: registration, protection period, non-circumvention, and conflict resolution all have documents behind them.

**If an asset is missing:** do not compensate with broad verbal promises. Create the asset before committing commercially. Use precise, limited language until the operating mechanism exists.

### 9.1 Capability statement

"AdaptCloud provides a partner-led platform and delivery method for repeatable cloud-security and compliance-automation work.

The current offering supports defined cloud, security, compliance-as-code, compliance-automation, and hardening use cases. Partner delivery is enabled through documented methods, accreditation, controlled releases, second-line product support, and formal escalation.

**Current stage:** production-oriented platform and partner-launch program. Early engagements are structured as joint, evidence-producing deliveries.

**What we seek to prove with launch partners:** faster and more repeatable production of reviewable control evidence and remediation outputs, under the partner's client relationship and brand.

**What we do not claim:** AdaptCloud does not independently grant compliance certification and does not replace accountable client personnel, authorized assessors, or auditors."

### 9.2 Account protection

"A partner-sourced opportunity becomes protected upon accepted deal registration. During the protection period, AdaptCloud will not pursue, quote, contract with, or solicit the registered account for the registered use case except through the originating partner, absent written consent.

Protection is subject to agreed activity expectations, defined renewal treatment, and a documented conflict-resolution process."

## 10 Final decision rule

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Advance to a paid, partner-led proof engagement only if the proposed relationship satisfies every condition below.

- 1 Gives the partner protected account ownership
  - 2 Produces sufficient recurring and services economics
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- |   |                                                        |
|---|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 3 | Has a defined support and escalation model             |
| 4 | Uses accredited delivery personnel                     |
| 5 | Creates traceable, reviewable evidence                 |
| 6 | Has bounded initial scope                              |
| 7 | Can generate measured, permissioned proof              |
| 8 | Does not require AdaptCloud to make unsupported claims |

**Otherwise: do not force a partnership.** Resolve the commercial, operational, or evidence gap first. A partnership signed over an unresolved gap converts that gap into a shared liability.